

Maintaining relationships

Antisocial maintenance behaviors

Behaviors that discourage interaction.

Behaviors that try to control or manipulate a partner.

Behaviors that attempt to change a partner.

Antisocial maintenance behaviors

The use of *some* anti-social maintenance behaviors is not necessarily bad for relationships.

- If used infrequently.

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors

Avoidance:

- Attempting to keep a relationship going by:
 - Evading the partner in certain situations or on certain issues
 - Avoiding conflict or disagreement
 - May be helpful in some instances.
 - “We are never going to agree on X, so we won’t talk about it.”

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors

Jealousy induction:

- Attempting to keep a relationship going by making a partner jealous
 - The goal is to redirect a partner's attention back to the relationship.
 - Can easily backfire.

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors – jealousy induction

Jealousy induction tends to be associated with fear that a partner is romantically interested in a third party.

People who employ jealousy induction often hope to create feelings of love and possessiveness in their partners

- Thus prompting a desire to remain actively engaged in the relationship.

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors – jealousy induction

- Examples of jealousy induction include:
 - purposely flirting with a potential rival in front of the partner.
 - commenting on the attractiveness of others in front of the partner.
 - talking about rivals in front of a partner.

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors

- **Spying:**

- Attempting to keep a relationship going by gaining information about your partner without their knowledge
 - "Keeping tabs" on a partner to make sure they are still invested in the relationship.
 - Online, in person.
- Spying is usually about wanting to control a partner; suggests a lack of trust.

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors

Communicative Infidelity:

- Engaging in sexual activity with someone else to send a message to the partner.
 - “Teach partner a lesson.”
 - Could be a means of revenge.
 - Could be a bid for attention.

Types of antisocial maintenance behaviors

Allowing control:

- Attempting to keep a relationship going by focusing exclusively on the partner and letting the partner make all of the decisions in a relationship.
- Ignoring friends and family.

Types of antisocial maintenance Behaviors

- **Destructive conflict:**

- Attempting to keep a relationship going by trying to control the partner using aggression.
 - Yelling at partner.
 - Abusing partner.
 - Starting arguments with partner so you can tell her/him what to do.

Maintenance in long-distance (LD) relationships

Researchers estimate that 25% to 40% of college students' romantic relationships are long-distance.

Because partners are not face-to-face, they engage in fewer pro-social maintenance behaviors

- E.g., task sharing, joint activities, social networking

Maintenance in long-distance (LD) relationships

Why do people find LD relationships satisfying?

- 1. partners can control the communication
 - E.g., timing of communication

Maintenance in long-distance (LD) relationships

Why do people find LD relationships satisfying?

- partners are often on their “best behavior” when together
 - Special activities

Maintenance in long-distance (LD) relationships

Why do people find LD relationships satisfying?

- Partner idealization
 - A person attributes exaggeratedly positive qualities to their partner
 - Note: some idealization is healthy in a relationship

Maintenance in long-distance (LD) relationships

It is not uncommon for LD relationships terminate when they become proximal and idealization fades

- Can't live up to idealized expectations.
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4-l89ep9ys4>

What is conflict?

Interpersonal conflict occurs in interactions where there are real or perceived incompatible goals, scarce resources, or opposing viewpoints.

Common conflict issues

Conflict in married couples tends to revolve around:

- 1. Household chores
- 2. Money
- 3. Jealousy
- 4. Sex
- 5. Children

Frequency of conflict in romantic relationships

Most romantic couples have between 1 and 3 small disagreements per week, and 1 or 2 serious disagreements per month

Frequency of conflict in romantic relationships

Some level of conflict is normal and healthy in close relationships.

- A total lack of conflict suggests that one partner is being too passive.

The way people **manage** conflict is more important than the frequency of conflict.

Gottman's couple types

Couples are classified by how they handle conflict in their relationships.

Whether a relationship lasts largely depends on how conflicts are managed.

Five couple types.

Gottman's couple types

1. Validating couples

- Put a great deal of emphasis on supporting and understanding their partner's point of view.
- Empathetic
- Tend to agree on issues such as sex, money, religion, and children.
- When disagreements occur, they work out compromises.
- Disagreements are calm and measured.
 - No shouting
 - No "below the belt" comments.

Gottman's couple types

2. Volatile couples

- Couple is comfortable with disagreement and lack of harmony.
- Communication style is emotionally expressive.
- Enjoy debate.
- Disagreements are settled through argument and discussion.
- Conflict tends to be productive and energizes the relationship.
- Communication is usually characterized by laughter, shared amusement, and humor.

Gottman's couple types

3. Conflict avoidant couples

- Do not like conflict.
- Not emotionally expressive.
- Emphasize common ground.
- Partners placate and please each other rather than meet their own needs.
- Often walk away from arguments.
- Achieve a clear balance between independence and interdependence.
- This couple type is most likely to have separate friends and interests.
 - But are also usually very connected when they engage in mutual interests.

Gottman's couple types

4. Hostile/engaged couples

- Argue frequently and usually in an unproductive way.
- Both partners are highly defensive.
- Frequent use of insults, sarcasm, and personal criticisms.

Gottman's couple types

5. Hostile/disengaged couples

- Argue frequently and usually in an unproductive way.
- During conflict, unable or unwilling to see the other person's perspective.
- Partners do not listen to one another.
- Emotional disengagement from the partner and the relationship.

Six conflict styles

The conflict style individuals use is often intergenerational.

- We tend to use the conflict styles we saw our parents use.
- Conflict styles are based on two dimensions:
 - 1. Degree of directness
 - the extent to which individuals talk directly about issues, express their opinions, and pursue their goals
 - 2. Degree of cooperativeness
 - the extent to which individuals consider the needs and perspectives of their partner.

Six conflict styles

1. Competitive fighting

2. Compromising

3. Collaborating

Six conflict styles

4. Indirect fighting

5. Avoiding

6. Yielding

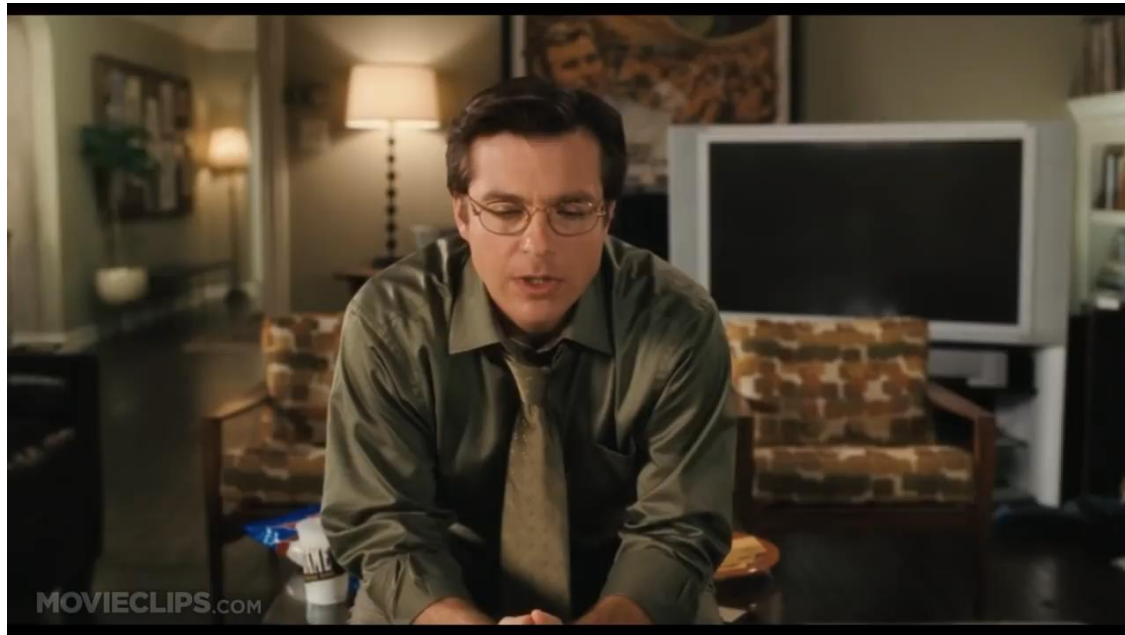
Competitive fighting

- Direct, aggressive, hostile, and uncooperative.
- Competing to defeat the partner/win the argument
- Win-lose orientation (I win, you lose)
 - “Win” is only temporary
- Usually associated with poor communication competence and relational dissatisfaction.

Competitive fighting

- Specific tactics include:
 - personal criticism
 - blaming or accusations
 - hostile questioning and teasing
 - demands and threats

Competitive fighting example



Compromising

- Direct, moderately cooperative.
- Part-win, part lose orientation
 - Each partner gives up something
- Quality of compromise varies based on how mutually acceptable the outcome is
 - Is the compromise fair to all parties?

Compromising

- Specific tactics include:
 - finding a middle ground
 - alternating

“Compromising”



Collaborating

- Direct and cooperative
- Win-win orientation
 - Creative problem solving to satisfy both partners' needs.
- Solution-oriented
- Most effective

Collaborating

- Specific tactics include:
 - Inquiring about the partner's feelings
 - Communicating support and empathy
 - Accepting responsibility
 - Emphasizing commonalities
 - Initiating problem-solving and brainstorming

Collaborating



Indirect fighting

Indirect, uncooperative, and hostile

Passive aggressive strategies

Focus on dismissing the partner's position and shutting down conversation in an effort not to lose the argument

Indirect fighting

Specific tactics include:

- ignoring the partner
- giving the silent treatment
- cold or dirty looks
- rolling one's eyes
- mean-spirited sarcasm

Avoiding

- Indirect, neutral cooperation
- Sometimes leads to a lose-lose situation with issues left unresolved
- However, in some cases, avoiding is beneficial.
 - Preferable to aggression
 - Choosing to avoid vs. feeling silenced
 - Topical; “agree to disagree.”

Avoiding

- Specific tactics include:
 - denying the conflict exists
 - being indirect and evasive about the conflict
 - changing topics

Yielding

- Cooperative, indirect
- Lose-win orientation (I lose, you win)
- Problematic if one person always gives in
- Beneficial if the conflict issue is more important to one partner than the other

Yielding

- Specific tactics include:
 - appeasement (giving in)
 - passive acceptance of alternative positions